The Notebook

The first one came back before five in the morning. He read it standing in the kitchen, in a t-shirt, with the fridge humming, because his bedroom felt like a place where someone might be watching him read it. The acceptance was a paragraph long. The editor said the story had a quality of waiting in it she had not seen done that way before. She used the word *patience* and then crossed it out — he could see the strikethrough, she had left it in — and replaced it with *refusal*. She said: *you have written a refusal that sounds like patience, and I think that is the story*.

He put the phone face down on the counter and then face up and then face down again. His mother's tin was on the shelf above the kettle, the lid not on straight, a fingerprint of turmeric on the rim where she had pressed it down with her thumb at six the night before. He could hear her in the next room, her breathing the breathing of someone whose alarm would go in twenty minutes. He did not wake her. He did not wake Tahmina, who was in Brampton anyway and would not have been there to wake. He stood until he registered, in his own head, the kettle starting — except the kettle was off. The fridge was cycling. He had supplied the kettle.

The thing he could not say to himself, then, in the kitchen: he had recognized the sentences in the story. Not as his — as ones he had been about to write. There were three. One about a man on the 25 Don Mills eating a samosa with one hand while holding a phone with the other, a flake of pastry caught in the man's beard which he kept not noticing; one about the way his mother folded a fitted sheet, the knuckle of elastic that always ended up loose at the corner because she would not be told that the corner was the corner; one about Anika, although the story was not about Anika and did not name her, only the part of her elbow that had been visible

against the door of the 7-Eleven on Sheppard the night she had told him she was going to marry someone else.

He had drafted these in his head, on the bus, on a Tuesday in February, between Eglinton and Lawrence. He had not written them down. He had thought: I will write them down when I get home. He had not written them down.

He had uploaded the notebook six weeks earlier. Tahmina had told him about the platform — not because she thought he was a writer, because she did not know he was a writer, but because she had read an article about it and forwarded it with the message *this looks like the kind of thing you would have an opinion about*. He had read the article. The platform offered something it called preparatory authorship. You uploaded what you had — drafts, fragments — and the system worked against the corpus, overnight, on cheap compute, building out what it called candidate continuations. When you logged in, your continuations were waiting. The article quoted a co-founder saying *we want to meet you where you would have gone*. Rashed had read this sentence twice and then signed up.

The free tier let you generate two stories from a small archive. He had uploaded the notebook — the first one, the green Hilroy with the cover bent back along the spiral so it lay flat on his thigh on the bus, the one he kept because if he lost it he would lose proof that he started — and the finished story, the one he had not sent. He had uploaded them at one in the morning, with the door shut, with his headphones on for no reason, because there was no audio. The progress bar took eight minutes. At the end the system said: *Preparing. Check back tomorrow.*

He had checked back the next morning and there had been one story. He had read it on the bus. He had missed his stop. He had read it again at his desk, with his coffee going cold beside the second monitor where the credit memos lived, and at the end of it he had done the thing he had not been able to do since he was seventeen, which was to want, very specifically, to be read by a person he did not know. He had sent the story to a magazine he had read for three years and had never

submitted to. He had not told anyone. Not Tahmina. Not his mother. Not the version of himself that had been waiting eleven months.

That was the first story. There was now a second.

He paid the upgrade fee on a Thursday. The fee was eighteen dollars. The platform thanked him in a banner the colour of a hospital corridor that disappeared without acknowledgement. The next story arrived on Saturday morning, and the small literary press wrote to him on Tuesday, and by the end of the month he had said yes to a contract for a collection — eight stories, ten if he could — and he had told his sister he had been "working on something" and she had said *good for you, finally*, and he had not corrected her.

He told himself, in the kitchen, that this was what it was supposed to feel like. That the waiting had been a way of not noticing the work was already done.

The pricing was on the third tab of the dashboard, under *Account*, in a section called *Compute Allocation*. He had not looked at it. He had paid the upgrade and another upgrade after that, and another, and he had paid them on his debit card without examining the line items, because the platform's invoicing was clean: *Generation: Story 04. $42.50.* He could read a credit memo. He could not read this.

The bill came through like a tooth he had not known was loose: a hundred and ninety dollars for a story he had not generated. He logged in. The line item said *Discarded preparation: candidate continuations, retained 14 days.* He clicked the question mark beside it.

Sleep-time compute is the work performed in anticipation of a request you have not yet made. We prepare a range of candidate continuations against your archive each night. When you generate, we serve the closest match. The remaining candidates are

retained for a short period and then released. You are billed for the preparation of all candidates within your active tier, not only for the candidate served.

He sat with this. The window in his bedroom faced the parking lot. A man in an oil-stained Carhartt — the green that has been washed past green into a kind of grey memory of green — was loading boxes into the back of a maroon Sienna with the side door that no longer slid all the way shut, the one the man strapped with a bungee cord every morning. He watched the man finish loading and stand with his hand flat on the dent at the top of the door before getting into the driver's seat. Then he opened a new tab and read the question mark again.

Released, he saw. Not deleted. Not discarded after all. *Released.*

He understood, then, that he had been paying for Rasheds. Not the one that wrote. All of them. The one that would have gone in another direction on Tuesday if he had eaten a different breakfast. The one that would have written the bus sentence and not written the sheet sentence. The one that would have written about Anika directly. The one that would have written about his father and abandoned the draft. Each night, while he was asleep, the platform was running through these Rasheds, choosing the ones it thought he would buy, holding them, dissolving them at the end of the fourteen-day window without his ever having met them.

The platform had the record of who he had not been. He had only the bill.

He paid the bill.

The collection's title story was not yet written. The contract had named it provisionally — *The Notebook* — and the editor had said, on the phone, *we love what we've seen, we want the title piece to be the one that holds it together*. He had said *of course* and *I'm working on it* and *give me three weeks*. He had two weeks left.

He sat down at the desk that had been Tahmina's, in the room that had been Tahmina's, with the window that faced the parking lot. The Hilroy was on the desk, closed, the spiral pressed flat against the wood from years of his palm. He opened a blank document. He waited for a sentence.

A sentence came. It was a good first sentence — the kind he had been told, by people who had read the published stories, was a thing he was good at. It said: *The first one I filled was the one I kept; the rest I lost on purpose.*

He stopped. He read it again.

He had written something close to this in the notebook, when he was nineteen — not this sentence, but its parent. He had also seen this sentence, or one very near it, in the second story the platform had generated for him. He had also, possibly, drafted this sentence on the bus on the morning he had uploaded the notebook, although he could not now be sure if the drafting had happened before the upload or after — if it was a sentence he had carried in and not written, or one the platform had given him, or one he had thought of in response to one the platform had given him, or one the platform had given him after he had thought of it, or one that had only existed once in his head and had been retrieved by the system from the corpus of his typing on his own laptop, which the platform had asked permission to index and which he had given permission to index in a checkbox on the third page of the onboarding.

He did not know whose sentence it was.

He sat with it for forty minutes. He tried to write the next one. He could not write the next one without knowing whose the first one was. He typed something, deleted it, typed something else, deleted it. The cursor blinked.

He opened the platform. He generated a candidate continuation from the first sentence, paying eighty dollars for a *deep* generation. He read the result. The result was good in particular ways. It used an em-dash where he would have used an em-dash, with the half-breath before it that meant the next clause was the thought and

the previous clause had been only the running start. It put *acha* in his father's mouth without italics, which he had not known until he read it was the choice he would have made — the italics, he understood reading it, were what made *acha* a word from elsewhere; the platform had let it stay a word from inside the house. The cadence of the second paragraph dropped its stresses on the same beats his cadence dropped them. It was better than what he had been about to write, possibly, because what he had been about to write had also been the platform's, which is to say it was the same sentence twice with different friction. He could not tell.

He thought of his sister. He thought of the article she had sent him. He thought of the first acceptance email and the strikethrough on *patience*. He thought of what the editor would say if he sent her a story whose first sentence he could not locate.

He pasted the platform's continuation into the document. He kept reading. The continuation knew about the bus, and about his mother folding the sheet, and about Anika without naming her, and it knew them all in a register he had spent fifteen years not being able to find when he tried — a register that had only ever come to him at one in the morning, in his old bed, with the headphones on for no reason.

He wrote the rest of the story across two nights. Some of the sentences were typed by his hands and were arguably his. Some were the platform's, lightly altered. Some were the platform's unaltered. He could not tell, by the end, which were which, because each time he changed a word he was not sure if he was changing the platform's word into his or his into the platform's. The seam was not in the document. The seam was in him, and it had moved into the place behind his teeth where a sentence forms before he says it, into the thing the dentist had told him last spring was a habit of clenching he could correct with a guard at night. He had not bought the guard. He clenched now whenever he sat at the desk. He had begun to taste, at the back of his tongue, the iron of his own gum where the molar pressed.

He sent the file to the editor at three in the morning. The editor wrote back at nine and said it was the best one yet.

The collection came out in September. He bought five copies at the launch and gave one to his mother, who put it on top of the microwave, where it stayed; one to his father, who said *acha* and put it on the shelf above the television and did not mention it again; one to his manager, who said *I had no idea*; one to himself; and one, in person, to Tahmina.

He gave Tahmina hers in her kitchen in Brampton. Her husband was in the other room watching cricket; the commentary came through the wall in the cadence of a thing being explained at length to someone who was not listening. She made tea without asking him if he wanted any. She broke the cardamom pods between her fingernails the way their mother did, two pods, the green husks left on the counter beside the kettle because she would sweep them into her palm later and not now. She took the book and turned it over and read the back and read the first page of the first story standing up, with one hand on the counter, the way she read everything. She read for a long time.

She closed the book. She put it on the counter beside the kettle, beside the cardamom husks. She looked at him.

"Rashed," she said.

He waited. He was good at waiting. He had been told.

"Did you write this."

He had rehearsed many things in the car on the way over. He had rehearsed: *yes, of course, who else.* He had rehearsed: *I worked with a tool.* He had rehearsed: *it's complicated*. He had rehearsed silence. He had rehearsed laughing.

What he said was: "Yes."

She looked at him for a second longer than she usually looked at him. She did not blink in that second, which was how he knew it was the second. Then she nodded — once, small — and picked up the book again and put it in the cloth bag with the No Frills logo she had brought in from the car, the one she would take upstairs later. She did not ask anything else. She poured the tea. She asked about their mother's knee. They talked about their mother's knee for nine minutes.

When he left she walked him to the door and hugged him the way she always hugged him, briefly, from the side, one arm, her other hand still holding the cardamom-smelling tea towel she had not put down. She said *I'm proud of you, bhaiya*, and the *bhaiya* — which she only used when she was teasing him, or when she meant it, and he could not always tell which — sat in the doorway after she closed the door and stayed there as he walked to the car.

He sat in the driver's seat in her driveway for some time before he started the engine. The streetlight at the end of the cul-de-sac was the sodium kind. It did to his hands what sodium does to brown skin, which is take the brown out and leave behind a colour that looks like a photograph of skin rather than skin. He looked at his hands on the wheel and they were not his hands. He thought about the sentence he had said. The *yes*. He could not take it back. He could write to her tomorrow. He could write to her in an hour. He could go back to the door right now and tell her about the platform, about the discarded preparations that were not discarded, about the seam he could not find. He could do any of these things and none of them would unsay the *yes*.

She had not believed him. He had seen the second of her looking. She had not pressed. She would never press. She would carry the not-believing with her for the rest of her life, the way he had carried his father's face the first time the man had picked up one of his report cards and put it back down without speaking, the way their mother — at sixty-one — would still go into the bathroom in the middle of dinner and turn the tap on full and cry and come out with her face washed and her

eyeliner reapplied and ask him if he wanted more rice. Tahmina would put the book on a shelf and she would mention it sometimes to her husband in the kind voice she used for things she had not made up her mind about, and the not-having-made-up-her-mind would be the form their relationship now took, because he had given her a thing he could not vouch for and had said, when she asked, that it was his.

He started the engine. He did not turn on the radio. He drove.

He did not stop using the platform. He had thought, in the driveway, that he might. He thought it again at home, sitting at the desk that had been Tahmina's. He thought it the next morning, drinking the coffee his mother had made and left for him on the counter under a small plate, and he thought it on the bus on the way to the bank, and he thought it at his desk where the credit memos still lived. By the evening he had paid for another deep generation, because the editor had asked, gently, whether there was a second collection in him, and he had said *probably*, and the *probably* had been the only honest thing he had said in a week.

The new generation cost two hundred and ten dollars. He paid it. He sat at the kitchen table while his mother heated dal in the microwave behind him — the old Panasonic with the broken light, the timer set for one minute thirty, the hum that started with a thunk because the turntable had been crooked since 2019 — and he opened the file the platform had prepared, and he read the first sentence, and the first sentence was a sentence about a sister in a kitchen.

His mother said, in Bangla, *eta thanda hoye gechhe, ami abar gorom kortechi*. *It got cold, I'm warming it again.* He did not hear her the first time. He heard her the second time and said *hyan, hyan, ek minute*. The minute did not come. The platform's sentence sat on the screen. Below it, the cursor blinked, waiting for him to begin choosing — to keep the sentence, to alter it, to delete it and write his own,

although his own was no longer a category he could verify. He read the sentence three times.

The microwave finished. The thunk of the turntable settling. His mother opened the door before the beep had finished its three beeps; she always did; she did not like the beep. She took the bowl out and set it on the counter and the small clatter of the bowl against the counter was the sound the kitchen made when she was in it, the sound that was not in the platform's archive because the platform's archive was the laptop and the laptop did not hear the kitchen. She said something else now, lower, to herself, about the dal, about the salt, the words too quiet for him to catch and also in the register she used only when she thought no one was listening, the register that was not in any file he had ever uploaded, that had never been typed, that existed only in the air of this apartment and in him and nowhere else.

He could feel, behind his teeth, the pressure of a sentence forming, his own, perhaps, or in response, perhaps, or having been the source, perhaps, of the platform's. He clenched. The molar against the gum. The taste.

He could not tell.

He kept reading.

The editor wrote on a Wednesday. She wanted to talk about the second collection. She wanted to know, also, if he would do an event in Toronto in November — a panel, three writers, a moderator who was a critic he had admired for years and whose first book he had taken out of the library so many times in 2014 that the librarian had eventually said *just take it, no one else is asking*. He said yes to the panel. He said he was thinking about the second collection. The editor said *take your time, I just wanted to put it on your radar*, and the *just* was the word he sat with

after he hung up, because *just* was the word people used when they were not just doing the thing they said they were just doing.

He logged in to the platform that night. There was a notification at the top of the dashboard, a small grey one, which he had learned meant either an upsell or a change to the terms. He clicked it.

Beginning next billing cycle, candidate continuations will be retained on a rolling basis. You will continue to be billed for preparation. Released candidates may be reviewed in the new Archive *tab, available to* Studio *tier subscribers.*

The Studio tier was four hundred dollars a month.

He upgraded.

The Archive tab loaded slowly. He watched the spinner. The spinner was the small grey one with eight spokes, the one that had been the same spinner on every website for fifteen years, and he thought, watching it, that the spinner was the only honest object on the platform — it was not pretending to know how long it would take, it was only turning. When the tab loaded it was a list. The list was long. Each row was a date and a fragment — the first eighty characters of a candidate continuation, in grey, with a small *open* beside it. The dates went back fourteen days. After fourteen days, he understood, the new policy would let them keep going.

He opened one at random.

It was a story about a woman who folded fitted sheets. The woman was not his mother. She had a different name, a name he had never used in anything, a name that had appeared exactly once in the notebook on a page from 2011 where he had been trying out names for a character he had then abandoned. The woman folded the sheets badly, and the badness was — the sentence said something about the badness that was not what he would have said about the badness; it was sharper, less sentimental, it said the badness was the part of the love that knew it would not be

checked, and he read this and felt, behind his teeth, the small click of a sentence he had not written being a sentence he agreed with.

He opened another.

It was about Anika. It named her.

He closed the tab. He opened it again. He scrolled. There were thousands. There were Rasheds who had written about his father directly, Rasheds who had written about the year he had not gone to his cousin's wedding, Rasheds who had written a story he could not finish reading about a boy in a kitchen in Dhaka in 1987 which was not a kitchen he had been in but was, in the third paragraph, recognizably the kitchen his mother had grown up in, which she had described to him exactly twice, once when he was eleven and once when he was twenty-four, and which he had never written down anywhere. He scrolled. The list kept loading. The spinner at the bottom turned.

He closed the laptop.

He did not move from the chair. The kitchen was dark. His mother had gone to bed an hour ago; he had heard the bathroom door, the tap, the small mechanical sigh of the medicine cabinet she always closed too hard. The light over the stove was on, the small one, which she left on for him when she went to bed first. The Hilroy was on the desk in the other room. He could feel it being there the way you feel a person in a room behind you. He did not get up to check on it. He knew what he would find. The Hilroy was on the desk, closed, the spiral flat.

He sat in the chair.

The thing he understood, sitting there, with the small light on over the stove and his mother's breath audible through two walls and the laptop closed in front of him and the molar pressed against the gum and the taste of the gum: the platform had not stolen anything. It had not given him anything either. It had only run, every night, against what was already in him, and it had found what was already in him faster than he could find it himself, and now he could not find anything in himself

without first checking whether the platform had found it first, and the checking had become the finding, and the finding had become the checking, and there was no sentence he could form that was not also a query.

He thought: I should call Tahmina.

He thought: it is one in the morning.

He thought: she would answer.

He thought: she would not believe what I told her.

He thought, more quietly, the thought he had been not-thinking for three months, the thought that had been waiting behind his teeth the way the molar had been waiting: she had not believed the first thing. She would not believe the second thing because she had not believed the first thing. The not-believing was already there. He could pour anything into it. The shape would not change.

He opened the laptop.

The Archive tab was still loaded. The spinner at the bottom was still turning. A new row had appeared at the top while the laptop had been closed — he watched the timestamp resolve itself, *2 minutes ago* — and the fragment beside it, the first eighty characters, said: *He sat in the chair. The thing he understood, sitting there, with the small li—*

He read it three times.

He clicked *open*.

The candidate was four hundred words long. It was good in particular ways. It used the molar. It used the taste. It used the sodium light from Tahmina's driveway as a callback in the third paragraph, which he had not thought to do but which, reading it, he understood he would now never not have thought to do, because now it had been thought. It ended on a sentence about the Hilroy on the desk that was the sentence he had been about to write next, before he had opened the laptop, before he had not-called Tahmina, before he had thought any of the things he had just thought.

The candidate had been generated, the timestamp said, at 12:51 a.m. He had closed the laptop at 12:49.

He looked at the timestamp for a long time. The platform had not been listening to the kitchen. The kitchen was not in the archive. The platform had only been running, on cheap compute, against what was already in him. The fact that it had reached, at 12:51, the place he had reached at 12:49 was not a fact about the platform. It was a fact about him. There were not enough places to reach. He had been reaching the same places for forty-one years, and the platform, which had his archive, had reached them too, two minutes after he did, because two minutes was how long the compute took.

He could feel, behind his teeth, the pressure of a sentence forming. He could not tell whose.

He started typing into the candidate's window, beneath the four hundred words. He typed: *I am sitting in the kitchen. It is one in the morning. My mother is asleep. I do not know if this sentence is mine.* He read what he had typed. He could not tell if it was his. It used the cadence the platform used. It used the cadence he used. The cadences had been the same cadence for some time now and he did not know when they had become the same. He kept typing. He typed for an hour. At the end of the hour he had three pages. He read them. They were good in particular ways.

He did not save them to his own machine. He left them in the platform's window. He understood, doing this, that he was leaving them there because he wanted the platform to have them, because the platform having them was the closest thing he had now to having written them, because the having-written had moved out of his hands and into the place where the platform and he were the same reach.

He closed the laptop.

His mother coughed in the bedroom, the small dry cough she did in her sleep, and turned over, and the bed creaked, and was still.

He kept the laptop closed. He sat. The light over the stove buzzed at the frequency it had buzzed since the bulb had gone half-bad in June. He had been meaning to change it. He had not changed it. The buzz was the sound of the kitchen now, the way the cardamom on Tahmina's counter had been the smell of Tahmina's kitchen, the way the tap on full had been the sound of his mother in the bathroom, the way the pages he had just typed were now what they were.

He opened the laptop.

The platform had generated a continuation of the three pages.

He read the first sentence.

He kept reading.

System: unslop.
Designed by: Rachel Horst (April 2026)
Models: claude-opus-4-7
Seed: A woman builds a fiction machine. Each story costs more than the last to produce. She keeps feeding it. By the time she understands what it's making, the meter is past anything she can pay.